to be a decision he would later regret. He now admits that his approach to the selection process had been ‘very idealistic’.

He decided to keep himself at arm’s length from the selection process to ensure complete transparency and equitableness. He wanted to have a committee consisting of members of equal standing, to eschew any allegation of undue influence. This would not have been possible if Ratan were part of it.

He had two other reasons to stay away. The first was that there were many aspirants from the Tata Group in the fray. He wanted to give the contenders the comfort and confidence of knowing that a collective body of equals would recommend one of them based on a unanimous decision, or if not, by a majority, and not on account of the chairman’s preference.

The second reason was more personal. Ratan recalls that the overwhelming view was that his half-brother Noel Tata was the ‘default candidate’ to succeed him. The Parsis in the company, as also the ‘traditionalists’ in the community, pushed for Noel’s appointment as they considered him to be one of them. They contended that it would prevent the break of a more-than-125-year-old tradition of only a Tata, or at least a Parsi related to the founder, heading the group.

Ratan, however, did not have any such concern. For him, only the talent and the values of the person mattered. Religion, community or the region they came from were hardly of relevance. He made it known that he was open to the committee even considering foreigners if they had the right qualifications.

Speaking at the Tata Chemicals’ AGM in August 2010, he said: ‘The Tata Group is an Indian group and we should not be looking at it as a Parsi group. The successor should be the right person and not anti-Parsi or pro-Parsi.’ He was also clear that he should not be seen as steering the selection committee or ‘pushing it in one direction or the other’. Even in the event of Noel not being selected, he did not want to be seen as ‘anti-Noel’. He told *The Times* that he ‘rose up through the business’ and added that even if he had a son, he would have ‘done something not to have that [his son automatically becoming his successor] happen’. Perhaps if Noel had had the experience of handling difficult assignments, he could have established his credentials more forcefully, says Ratan. Most importantly, he could have had the opportunity to demonstrate the ‘courage and enterprise’ that JRD had identified as a prerequisite to be appointed as chairman of the group.